Professor Zaehner and the Comparison of Religions

For about two hundred years now Indian philosophies and religions have been so persistently misrepresented and distorted by foreign writers that the Indians, both Hindus and Buddhists, are not only repelled by it all but have almost given up being concerned about it. It is indeed fortunate that there are still a few sound foreign interpreters of Indian thought and that the intelligent reader has begun to be discriminating about his choice of authors on Indian philosophies and religions. The number of accurate writers is increasing in contemporary times, and it is hoped that writers of the other category will soon disappear. But, amazingly enough, an extreme representative of the latter now speaks from the distinguished chair of the Spalding Professor of Eastern Religions and Ethics, University of Oxford, England. Because of his high position, the danger is great that he is more likely to mislead readers than are other non-Indian writers. There is some need, therefore, to correct, if possible, Zaehner himself, or if that is not possible, at least warn his readers against his "comparison of religions."

Zaehner had written a good book, *Mysticism, Sacred and Profane*. This was the reason I picked up a paperback edition of his *The Comparison of Religions,*[1] which appears to me to be the most astounding book in recent times on the subject. In this book Zaehner has perpetuated not only the most astonishing, if not shocking, misrepresentations about Hinduism and Buddhism as religions, but has scrapped as mere rubbish the noblest efforts of the best minds in India for over three thousand years in the realm of penetration into the mysteries, values, and destiny of human existence in preference to the exclusive Christian revelations which he mistakenly considers to be a rational examination of all the big religions of the world. I feel it, therefore, obligatory to deal with this book—but only insofar as it concerns Hinduism, for to